

UNDERSTAND YOUR ANALYTICS USING FREE TOOLS

GUIDE 4 OF 5

Understand Your Analytics Using Free Tools

Turn your free data into smarter decisions and faster growth

Understanding what your data is telling you is the single most powerful move you can make for your social media strategy.

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INTRODUCTION: WHY ANALYTICS ARE YOUR SECRET WEAPON

You've been showing up. You've been posting consistently, crafting captions, picking hashtags, and building a presence — exactly what Guides 1, 2, and 3 of this series prepared you for. That's already more than most small businesses do. But here's the uncomfortable truth: posting without looking at your data is like driving with your eyes closed.

Studies consistently show that the majority of small business owners either ignore their analytics entirely or only glance at surface-level numbers like follower counts and likes. The reasons are understandable — analytics dashboards can look intimidating, the jargon feels foreign, and it's tempting to assume that if engagement is "up," everything must be working. But that assumption is costing you real growth.

Here's the good news: you don't need to pay for analytics software. Every major platform — Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, LinkedIn, Pinterest, X (Twitter), and YouTube — gives you powerful built-in analytics completely free. Add Google Analytics 4 and a handful of free third-party tools, and you have a complete analytics stack that costs exactly \$0.

This guide will demystify analytics for you. By the end, you'll know exactly which numbers to track, where to find them, how to read them, and most importantly — how to turn data into decisions that grow your business.

SECTION 1

ANALYTICS 101: THE METRICS THAT ACTUALLY MATTER

Vanity Metrics vs. Meaningful Metrics

Not all numbers are created equal. Some metrics feel good but don't tell you much about your business health. Others — the ones that are slightly less glamorous — are the ones that actually drive decisions. Let's separate the two.

The 5 Core Metrics Every Small Business Should Track

What "Good" Looks Like: Benchmarks by Platform

Benchmark ranges vary by industry and audience size, but the table below gives you realistic targets for organic (unpaid) content as a small business owner.

SECTION 2

FREE NATIVE ANALYTICS BY PLATFORM

Every major social platform gives you analytics built right in — no subscription required. The trick is knowing where to look and which numbers to prioritize. Here's your platform-by-platform guide.

Instagram Insights

Instagram Insights is available to any account switched to a Professional Account (Business or Creator) — completely free. Access it by tapping your profile picture, then the hamburger menu (≡) → Insights. You can view data for the last 7, 14, 30, 60, or 90 days, or a custom range up to 2 years.

What to track: Reach, Impressions, Profile Visits, Website Taps, Follower count changes, and per-post metrics including Saves (a strong signal of valuable content). For Reels, pay close attention to Plays and Shares.

Export: Instagram does not offer a native CSV export for personal dashboards. Use Meta Business Suite (covered in Section 4) or a third-party tool like Metricool to export Instagram data.

Facebook Page Insights / Meta Business Suite Analytics

Facebook Page Insights lives at [facebook.com/\[YourPage\]/insights](https://facebook.com/[YourPage]/insights). Meta Business Suite (business.facebook.com) provides a more comprehensive view that combines Facebook + Instagram in one place. Access it via your Facebook Page → Professional Dashboard or directly through Meta Business Suite.

What to track: Post Reach, Engagement Rate, Page Likes growth, Reach by post type, and the "People" tab for audience demographic insights (age, gender, location). The location data is particularly useful for local Tulsa businesses confirming their audience is geographically relevant.

Export: Meta Business Suite allows CSV/Excel export of page and post data under the Insights → Export Data tab.

TikTok Analytics

TikTok Analytics is available on Business Accounts (free) and Creator Accounts. Access via Profile → the three-line menu → Creator Tools → Analytics. You can view data for the last 7, 28, or 60 days, or a custom range up to 60 days.

What to track: Video Views, Profile Views, Follower count and growth, Average Watch Time (crucial — TikTok's algorithm heavily rewards watch time), Completion Rate, and Traffic Source Types (For You Page vs. Following vs. Search).

Export: TikTok allows CSV export of analytics data on desktop — go to TikTok.com → Creator Center → Analytics → click "Export Data."

LinkedIn Page Analytics

Available to any LinkedIn Page admin. Navigate to your Page → Analytics tab. This covers Visitors, Followers, Leads (if using Lead Gen Forms), and Content performance.

What to track: Unique Visitors, New Followers, Impressions, Engagement Rate per post, and the Follower Demographics section (industry, job function, company size) — essential if you serve a B2B or professional audience.

Export: LinkedIn offers CSV export for visitor and follower analytics from the Analytics tab. Post-level data can be exported from the Content section.

Pinterest Analytics

Access at analytics.pinterest.com (requires a free Business Account). Pinterest analytics are unique because Pins have a very long lifespan — a great Pin can drive traffic for months or years.

What to track: Impressions, Engagements, Pin Clicks (clicks to your website — this is gold for Tulsa-based e-commerce and product businesses), Saves, and Outbound Clicks. The "Audience Insights" tab shows you your followers' interests.

Export: Use the date picker and "Export" button on any analytics page for a CSV download.

X (Twitter) Analytics

Access at analytics.twitter.com. X Analytics provides 28 days of data on the main dashboard, with individual tweet metrics available indefinitely. Note: X has changed its free analytics offering over time — core post metrics remain accessible at no cost.

What to track: Impressions, Engagements, Engagement Rate, Link Clicks, Profile Clicks, and the monthly 28-day summary of top-performing tweets.

Export: X allows CSV export of tweet activity data from the Tweet Activity dashboard.

YouTube Studio Analytics

Access via studio.youtube.com — free for any YouTube channel. YouTube Studio offers some of the most detailed analytics of any platform, with data going back to your channel's creation.

What to track: Views, Watch Time (hours), Average View Duration, Click-Through Rate (on thumbnails — critical for growth), Subscribers gained/lost, Traffic Sources, and the Audience tab (returning vs. new viewers, when your audience is online). For local businesses, the Geography tab confirms your local reach.

Export: In YouTube Studio, go to Analytics → select a report → click the "Export" button (top right) for CSV or Google Sheets export.

Platform Analytics Quick-Reference

SECTION 3

GOOGLE ANALYTICS 4 (FREE) FOR SOCIAL MEDIA

Why Connect Website Analytics to Your Social Strategy?

Your social media platforms tell you what's happening on social. Google Analytics 4 (GA4) tells you what happens after someone clicks. Did they buy something? Did they call you? Did they read your blog? Did they bounce after 3 seconds? That second half of the story is where the real business decisions get made — and GA4 gives it to you completely free.

Setting Up GA4 (Free Overview)

If you haven't set up GA4 yet, here's the short version:

Go to analytics.google.com and sign in with your Google account.

Click "Start measuring" and create an Account (your business) and a Property (your website).

Select "Web" as your data stream and enter your website URL.

Copy your Measurement ID (format: G-XXXXXXXXXX) and add it to your website via Google Tag Manager, your CMS (Squarespace, Wix, WordPress all have built-in GA4 integrations), or by pasting the code snippet into your site's <head> tag.

Verify data is flowing in Real-Time → Overview within 24–48 hours.

How to Track Social Media Traffic to Your Website

In GA4, navigate to Reports → Acquisition → Traffic Acquisition. Set the primary dimension to "Session source / medium." You'll see traffic grouped by channel, including "organic social" — this shows you how many website sessions came from social media platforms. Drill down by platform to see Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, etc. individually.

Key metrics to review in this report: Sessions, Engaged Sessions, Engagement Rate, Average Engagement Time, and Conversions (if you've set up conversion events like form submissions or purchases).

UTM Parameters: What They Are and How to Build Them Free

UTM parameters are small tags added to the end of your website URLs. They tell GA4 exactly which social post, platform, or campaign sent a visitor to your site. Without them, GA4 often can't correctly attribute social media traffic — meaning your hard work goes uncounted.

A UTM-tagged URL looks like this:

The five UTM parameters are:

utm_source — Where the traffic comes from (e.g., instagram, facebook, tiktok, linkedin)

utm_medium — The channel type (e.g., social, organic-social, bio-link)

utm_campaign — The specific campaign or promotion (e.g., summer-sale, grand-opening)

utm_content — Differentiates similar posts (e.g., reel-v1, carousel-post)

utm_term — Optional; used for paid keyword tracking

Build UTM URLs for free: Use Google's Campaign URL Builder at ga-dev-tools.google/campaign-url-builder. Fill in your website URL and UTM fields, and it generates the tagged URL instantly. Shorten it with Bitly (free) before posting if the full URL looks unwieldy.

Reading the Acquisition → Traffic Source Report in GA4

Once UTM-tagged links have been live for a few weeks, go to Reports → Acquisition → Traffic Acquisition and filter by your campaign name. You can compare which social platforms drive the most engaged visitors, which campaigns sent traffic that actually converted, and which posts resulted in visitors who left immediately (low Engagement Rate = low-quality traffic from that source).

SECTION 4

FREE THIRD-PARTY ANALYTICS TOOLS

Beyond native platform dashboards, a growing ecosystem of third-party tools offers free-tier plans that help you see multiple platforms in one place, schedule posts with basic analytics, and even build custom reporting dashboards. Here are the most valuable free options for small businesses.

Meta Business Suite

If you're active on Facebook and/or Instagram, Meta Business Suite (business.facebook.com) is your free, unified command center. It combines posting, scheduling, messaging, and analytics for both platforms in one interface. The Insights section includes audience demographics, reach and engagement trends, and post-level breakdowns. You can also export data as CSV — making it the best native tool for FB + IG combined reporting.

Later (Free Plan)

Later is best known as a visual scheduling tool for Instagram, but its free plan also includes basic analytics: engagement rate per post, best times to post (based on your audience's activity), and a high-level performance overview for posts scheduled through Later. Limited to Instagram on the free plan, but very useful for visual content planning tied to performance.

Buffer (Free Plan)

Buffer's free plan allows you to connect up to 3 social channels and provides analytics on published posts — likes, comments, shares, reach, and engagement rate. It shows 30 days of post-level data on the free tier. While limited compared to paid plans, Buffer's analytics are clean, easy to read, and perfect for small businesses just getting started with third-party reporting.

Metricool (Free Plan)

Metricool is one of the most powerful free analytics tools available for small businesses. The free plan covers one profile per platform across Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, LinkedIn, Pinterest, X (Twitter), YouTube, and even Google Business Profile. You get a unified dashboard, post-level analytics, best posting time recommendations, competitor analysis (limited), and a weekly automated email report. This is the closest thing to a "social media analytics suite" you'll find at no cost.

Google Looker Studio (Free)

Formerly known as Google Data Studio, Looker Studio (lookerstudio.google.com) is a free data visualization and reporting tool that connects to Google Analytics 4, Google Search Console, Google Sheets, and hundreds of other data sources. You can build a fully custom social media performance dashboard that automatically updates — no manual data entry required. It takes an hour or two to set up, but once built, it becomes your permanent analytics home base.

Free Tool Comparison

SECTION 5

BUILDING A MONTHLY ANALYTICS REVIEW

The businesses that improve fastest aren't the ones with the best tools — they're the ones with the most consistent review habits. A monthly analytics review doesn't need to take more than 60–90 minutes. Here's a proven framework for making it efficient and actionable.

Monthly Review Checklist

Pull data from each active platform for the past 30 days (or use Metricool's unified dashboard)

Record total Reach and Impressions for each platform

Calculate or pull Engagement Rate for each platform (compare to prior month)

Identify your Top 3 Posts by reach AND your Top 3 Posts by engagement rate (these may be different)

Identify your Bottom 3 Posts — what made them underperform?

Check Follower Growth Rate on each platform

Pull GA4 → Traffic Acquisition: how much website traffic came from social this month?

Check UTM-tagged campaign performance: which links drove the most clicks?

Review your Audience Insights: any shifts in demographics or location? (Especially important for local Tulsa businesses)

Note which content formats performed best: video, image, carousel, text?

Note which topics/themes resonated most with your audience

Identify which posting days and times generated the highest engagement

Document one thing to double down on, one thing to stop doing, and one new thing to test

The "What Worked / What Didn't / What to Test" Framework

After gathering your data, run it through this simple three-column thinking exercise:

Sample Monthly Performance Report Template

Key Questions to Ask Every Month

What content got the most reach — and why? (Format, topic, timing, hashtags?)

What drove the most link clicks to my website this month?

Which day and time consistently performed best on each platform?

Did my audience demographics shift? Am I reaching the right people?

What is my best-performing platform this month — and am I investing enough there?

Did I hit any of my goals from last month's review? Why or why not?

SECTION 6

A/B TESTING FOR FREE

What A/B Testing Means on Social Media

A/B testing — sometimes called split testing — means creating two versions of something (Version A and Version B), changing only one variable between them, posting both, and seeing which performs better. On social media, you don't need special software or a large audience to run meaningful tests. You just need a plan, some patience, and a simple tracking sheet.

The goal isn't to prove a theory — it's to let your audience tell you what they prefer. And they'll tell you clearly, through their behavior.

Simple Tests Small Businesses Can Run

How to Track A/B Test Results in a Free Google Sheet

Create a Google Sheet with the following columns to track every test you run:

Test Name — Descriptive label (e.g., "Hook Test #1 — May 2026")

Variable Tested — What changed between the two versions

Version A Description — What you did in Version A

Version B Description — What you did in Version B

Platform — Where the test ran

Post Date A / Post Date B — When each went live

Primary Metric — The single number you're measuring

Result A / Result B — The actual numbers

Winner — Which version won

Action Taken — What you're changing in your strategy based on the result

The Minimum Sample Size to Trust Your Results

This is where many small businesses go wrong: they run a test once and declare a winner. One data point is not a pattern. Here are practical minimums for trusting your A/B test results on social media:

Reach: Each post should reach at least 500–1,000 unique accounts before drawing conclusions

Engagement Rate: Compare posts with similar reach — testing a post that reached 200 people against one that reached 2,000 is not a fair comparison

Time Testing: Run each posting-time test at least 3 times each (3 posts at Tuesday 8 AM, 3 posts at Thursday 6 PM) before concluding one is better

Statistical confidence rule of thumb: If one version consistently outperforms the other across 3 or more trials, you can treat it as a meaningful signal

Control for external variables: Don't test posting times during a holiday week, a viral news event, or when you're also running a promotion — those factors will skew your results

SECTION 7

TURNING DATA INTO ACTION

The Optimization Loop: Post → Measure → Learn → Improve

Every piece of content you publish is a piece of data. Every metric is feedback from your audience. The businesses that grow consistently on social media aren't necessarily the most creative — they're the most systematic about applying what they learn. The optimization loop is your engine for compounding improvement.

Reading Patterns Over 30, 60, and 90 Days

Social media performance is not linear. Algorithms change, trends shift, and audience behavior evolves. Here's how to think about different time windows:

30 days: Enough to spot post-level patterns and confirm or disprove a hypothesis. Good for A/B test conclusions and monthly review insights.

60 days: Enough to identify consistent trends in format performance and follower growth trajectory. Are your Reels consistently outperforming carousels? Now you know.

90 days: The most reliable window for strategic decisions. A 90-day trend is hard to argue with. If short-form video has outperformed every other format for 90 days straight, it's time to make it your primary content type.

When to Double Down vs. When to Experiment

One of the most common mistakes in social media strategy is abandoning things that work too early, or staying too long with things that aren't working. Use this framework to decide:

Signs Your Strategy Needs a Pivot vs. Just More Time

Your strategy needs more time if: You've been consistent for fewer than 60 days, you've only tested one or two content formats, your metrics are flat but not declining, and your posting schedule has been inconsistent.

Your strategy needs a pivot if: Reach and engagement have declined for 90+ consecutive days, your follower growth rate is consistently negative, you're getting zero website traffic from social

despite consistent posting, and A/B tests aren't producing any winners — meaning no format is connecting.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Stop chasing vanity metrics. Focus on Reach, Engagement Rate, CTR, Follower Growth Rate, and Conversions — the five metrics that actually reflect business health.

Every major platform gives you powerful free analytics. Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, LinkedIn, Pinterest, X, and YouTube all have built-in insights dashboards at no cost.

Google Analytics 4 closes the loop. It tells you what happens after the click — which social posts drive real website visits and conversions.

UTM parameters are non-negotiable. Without them, you're flying blind on which social posts actually drive traffic. Build them using Google's free Campaign URL Builder.

Metricool's free plan is the best single-tool solution for most small businesses wanting a unified multi-platform analytics dashboard.

A consistent monthly review is more valuable than the fanciest tool. Use the checklist and template in Section 5 and do it every month without fail.

A/B test one variable at a time. Build real knowledge about your specific audience by changing just one thing per test and tracking results in a free Google Sheet.

The optimization loop is your growth engine. Post → Measure → Learn → Improve. Every piece of content makes you smarter. Don't skip the measuring step.

Read patterns over 90 days before making major strategic pivots. Short-term fluctuations are noise; 90-day trends are signals.

The Free Social Media Marketing Playbook for Small Businesses | Guide 4 of 5: Understand Your Analytics Using Free Tools

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